

INDO-US NUCLEAR DEAL, 2008

# Ending India's Nuclear Pariah Status

**The Indo-US nuclear deal saw the US break ranks with the gatekeepers of nuclear technology to admit India into the global nuclear trade. It led to closer strategic ties with Washington**

BY PRADIP R. SAGAR

The Indo-US Civil Nuclear Agreement, signed in 2008, marked a transformative moment in India's diplomatic and strategic history. Also known as the 123 Agreement, it not only signified a new era in India-US relations but also had profound implications for India's energy and technological ambitions. The deal sought to undo India's isolation from international nuclear trade and the global sanctions it faced after it conducted nuclear tests in 1974 and 1998. Despite restrictions, India refused to sign the Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty (NPT), asserting that it was discriminatory. However, India maintained an impeccable record in non-proliferation and developed a robust indigenous nuclear programme.

In the early 2000s, as India's economy grew, its energy demands skyrocketed. Nuclear energy emerged as a solution to address this but shortage of Uranium was a stumbling block. The US, led by President George W. Bush, recognised India's strategic potential as a partner in countering global challenges, including terrorism and the rise of China. The nuclear deal became a cornerstone of the India-US strategic partnership.

The Indo-US Civil Nuclear Agreement aimed to allow India access to global nuclear technology and fuel markets while ensuring compliance with certain non-proliferation norms. Key provisions were the separation of civil and military programmes and placing the former under International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) safeguards. The deal enabled India to continue to develop its nuclear weapons capability, including allowing weapons grade nuclear reactors to remain out of IAEA scrutiny. It paved the way for

**DID YOU KNOW?**

**It was the first time the US entered into a nuclear agreement with a country that was not a signatory to the Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty (NPT)**

**7,800**
**TONNES**
**Amount of nuclear fuel that India imported from 2008-09 to 2017-18**